A Saga of Heroism...

India-Pakistan War 1971



Lt Gen AAK Niazi signing the Instrument of Surrender at Dhaka on 16 December 1971 with Lt Gen JS Aurora (GOC-in-C East). Standing (L to R) Vice Admiral N Krishnan (FOC-in-C East), Air Marshal Dewan (AOC-in-C East), Lt Gen Sagat Singh, Maj Gen JFR Jacob (Chief of Staff Eastern Army)



Map of India and its neighbours

Battlefield is a Playground for War Heroes!

The world as we know today was not like this always. Influenced by various factors, it keeps on changing. War has been a major factor in shaping the course of history. The 1971 war dramatically changed the situation in India's neighbourhood. It was in this war, that India, since its Independence had achieved a conclusive victory and the credit goes to the concerted efforts and supreme sacrifices of our brave soldiers.

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Here are the stories of four such war heroes, who were awarded the Param Vir Chakra, the highest wartime gallantry medal in India. But, let us first understand the backdrop of the 1971 war (see map).

Why Did It All Begin?

We know Pakistan came into existence on 14 August 1947. At that time, it was split into two, one each on either side of India, namely West Pakistan and East Pakistan (which emerged later as Bangladesh in 1971). But West Pakistan insisted on total domination over the other. Urdu was declared as the sole official language of the entire Pakistan. However, many students in East Pakistan sacrificed their lives on 21 February 1952 for the cause of Bengali language, their mother tongue.

The first general elections for the entire Pakistan were held in 1970. On one hand, Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, achieved a landslide victory in East Pakistan. On the other, Zulfikar Ali Bhutto won most of the seats in West Pakistan. But the military and civilian leaders based in West Pakistan rejected this popular verdict and refused to share power with the elected representatives of East Pakistan.

On 26 March 1971 (which later became the Independence Day of Bangladesh), the Pakistani Army launched operations against the Bengali nationalists. A reign of terror was unleashed on the people of East Pakistan. The government had indulged in genocide against its own people! The differences between the eastern and western parts of Pakistan became irreconcilable. Thus, the break-up of Pakistan appeared increasingly inevitable.

Throughout 1971, India had to accommodate about ten million refugees coming from East Pakistan. West Bengal and the North East region were severely affected by the massive influx. But India continued to extend both moral and material support wholeheartedly to the just cause of the freedom struggle in East Pakistan. This, however, was strongly contested by West Pakistan.

On the global front, by the early 1970s, the US and China began to cooperate. Henry Kissinger, the advisor to the then US President Richard Nixon, made a secret visit to China via Pakistan in July 1971.

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To counter the US-Pakistan-China axis, India signed the 20-year Treaty of Peace and Friendship with the Soviet Union in August 1971.

Launching of Operations

The Indian military intervention became inevitable, in view of the pre-emptive strikes launched by Pakistan against India on 3 December 1971. The Chief of the Army Staff, Gen Sam Manekshaw, masterminded the campaigns. During this 14-day war, India mostly adopted aggressive strategies on the eastern front and defensive strategies on the western front. The Indian armed forces fought in close collaboration with the people in East Pakistan. The pro-Pakistan tilt of the US was clearly displayed when it dispatched its aircraft carrier to the Bay of Bengal during the war. This move deeply distressed India. At last, the Pakistani forces in Bangladesh – about 90,000 Prisoners of War (PoWs) surrendered to the forces of India and Bangladesh on 16 December 1971.

This day is commemorated as *Vijay Diwas* (Victory Day) both in Bangladesh and India. India, thus, played the role of a catalyst in the Liberation War of Bangladesh. India immediately announced a unilateral ceasefire on the western front. The hostilities ended finally with the signing of the Simla Agreement by Indira Gandhi and Zulfikar Ali Bhutto on 3 July 1972.

In the 1971 war, unlike the earlier wars, India achieved a decisive victory. This war was replete with tales of extraordinary courage displayed by the Indian armed forces – Army, Air Force and Navy – both on the eastern and western fronts. India suffered more than 12,000 casualties of which about 3,000 lost their lives. Nearly 600 officers and men of the armed forces were decorated with gallantry medals of which four were awarded the Param Vir Chakra (PVC), 76 Maha Vir Chakra (MVC) and 513 Vir Chakra (VrC).

The war heroes who were awarded the PVC were Lance Naik Albert Ekka (posthumously), Flying Officer Nirmal Jit Singh Sekhon (posthumously), 2/Lt Arun Khetarpal (posthumously) and Maj Hoshiar Singh. All four of them hailed from a wide range of socio-economic backgrounds. They personified valour in unique ways in different theatres of the war! Let us find out more about them.

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12

Albert Ekka



Born on 27 December 1942 in a tribal family, Albert Ekka was the son of Julius and Mariam Ekka. His village Jari in district Gumla is about 175 kilometres from Ranchi, Jharkhand. He had always been a jovial child and grew up to be an optimistic individual with a happy-go-lucky attitude. Adventurous by nature, he dreamed to join the Indian Army.

His dream turned into a reality on his twentieth birthday, when he enrolled himself in the 14th Battalion, Brigade of the Guards. His skill of hunting with bow and arrow in the jungle proved to be advantageous in the Army. He was always right on target with the guns as well! His marksmanship of the very first order was admired by one and all. He also excelled in games, especially hockey. He served in the counter-insurgency operations in the North East region. Nine years into the service, he was ready to accomplish the greatest mission of his life!

When the 1971 war broke out, the Indian armed forces fought on the eastern and western fronts as well. The Battle of Gangasagar was crucial in paving the way for the movement of the Indian troops towards their ultimate target in Bangladesh. The contribution of Lance Naik Albert Ekka to India's victory in this battle was immense.

Breaching the Enemy Defences

During the 1971 war, the 14 Guards had to capture a Pakistani position at Gangasagar, about six kilometres west of Agartala, Tripura, on the eastern front. This was located on a major railway link to Dacca (now Dhaka). Owing to its strategic location, the post

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was turned into a fortress by the enemy. The entire area was heavily mined. But the capture of Gangasagar was the key that would lead to the capture of Akhaura, on the way to Dhaka. So the 14 Guards launched an attack on enemy positions on the night of 3 December.

Lance Naik Albert Ekka was confident and determined to overcome the odds. He knew that it was time to 'do or die' for the nation and considered his duty to be his religion. He confidently spearheaded the attacks during this operation.

Col O.P. Kohli (Retd), then a Captain, was commanding this mission. He knew Albert Ekka from the time the latter joined the Army. He described his steely resolve thus: "A sort of an introvert in social circles, Ekka was very demonstrative during the exercises and training before the War. His looks were extremely deceptive and he didn't seem to be very active physically but had it not been for him, the objective may not have been achieved that day. A very keen soldier, Ekka insisted on leading the file formation... I was a few feet from him when he came across a Pakistani sentry. "*Kaun hai wahan* (Who's there)?," the sentry challenged and Ekka replied, "*Tera baap* (Your father)," before charging with his bayonet."

Risking his life, Lance Naik Albert Ekka single-handedly achieved two major breakthroughs by smashing the strongholds of the enemy. Epitomising the motto of the Brigade of the Guards, "*Pahla, Hamesha Pahla*" (First, Always First), he led the assault. He swiftly cleared the bunkers and silenced the LMG. Undaunted by the continuous shelling, he reached behind the enemy lines. Although grievously wounded in these close encounters, Lance Naik Albert Ekka continued to pursue the objectives of his company relentlessly. He soon destroyed the MMG.

During the mission, he eliminated several enemies and fought until his last breath. His actions saved the lives of his colleagues and helped them to advance towards their next target. The fall of Gangasagar forced the enemy to vacate Akhaura. Soon, the Indian troops were on their victorious march towards Dhaka.

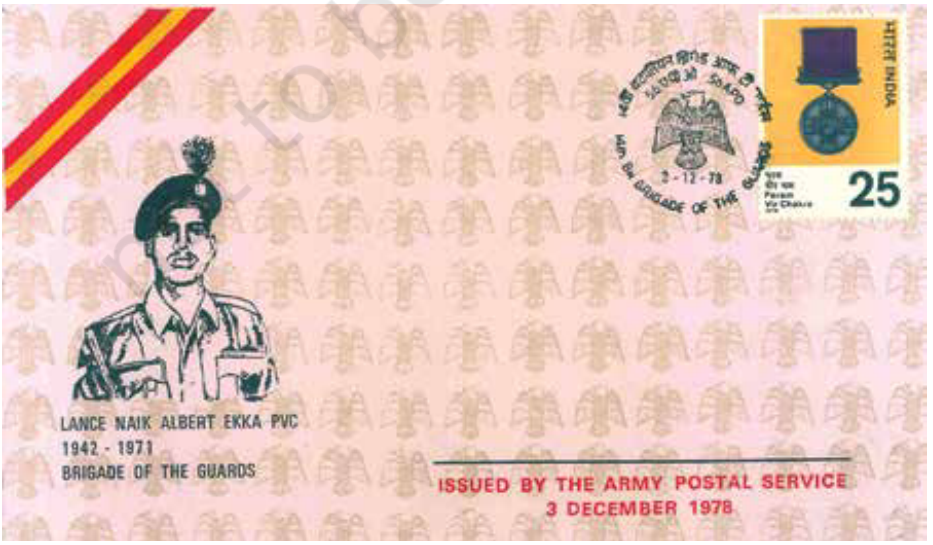
This young soldier of 29 years was posthumously awarded the Param Vir Chakra for his exceptional valour. This was the one and only Param Vir Chakra awarded for action on the eastern front. He left behind his wife Balamdina and a five-year-old son, Vincent. To

honour him, the Army Postal Service issued a Special Cover on 3 December 1978.

A major road junction in Ranchi was named as Albert Ekka Chowk, and his life-size statue was installed. A commemorative postage stamp was also issued in his honour by the Government of India on the occasion of the 50th Republic Day in 2000. A block (subdivision) in his home district of Gumla was named as Albert Ekka Block.



*Balamdina Ekka lays wreath at the war memorial near the burial site of Albert Ekka, PVC, in Dukli near Agartala, Tripura (*The Hindu*, 10 January 2016)*



Citation



Lance Naik Albert Ekka (No. 4239746), 14 Guards

Lance Naik Albert Ekka was in the left forward company of a Battalion of the Brigade of Guards during their attack on the enemy defence at Gangasagar on the eastern front. This was a well fortified position held in strength by the enemy. The assaulting troops were subjected to intense shelling and heavy small arms fire, but they charged on to the objective and were locked in bitter hand-to-hand combat. Lance Naik Albert Ekka noticed an enemy Light Machine Gun inflicting heavy casualties on his company. With complete disregard to his personal safety, he charged the enemy bunker, bayoneted two enemy soldiers and silenced the Light Machine Gun. Though seriously wounded in this encounter, he continued to fight alongside his comrades through the mile deep objective, clearing bunker after bunker with undaunted courage. Towards the northern end of the objective, one enemy Medium Machine Gun opened up from the second storey of a well fortified building inflicting heavy casualties and holding up the attack. Once again this gallant soldier without a thought to his personal safety, despite his serious injury and the heavy volume of enemy fire, crawled forward till he reached the building and lobbed a grenade through the loophole of the bunker, killing one enemy and injuring the other. The Medium Machine Gun, however, continued to fire. With outstanding courage and grim determination, Lance Naik Albert Ekka scaled a side wall and entering the bunker, bayoneted the enemy who was still firing and thus silenced the Machine Gun, saving further casualties to his company and ensured the success of the attack. In this process, however, he received serious injuries and succumbed to them after the capture of the objective.

In this action, Lance Naik Albert Ekka displayed the most conspicuous valour, determination and made the supreme sacrifice in the best traditions of the Army.

Gazette of India Notification
No. 7 – Pres./72

13

Nirmal Jit Singh Sekhon



Nirmal Jit was born on 17 July 1945 to Sardar Trilok Singh Sekhon and Harbans Kaur. His village, Issewal is located in the vicinity of the Halwara Air Force Station, near Ludhiana, Punjab. Since his childhood, he was fascinated by the aircrafts. He was fond of stories of the famous warrior of the early 19th century, Hari Singh Nalwa. Moreover, he was inspired by the experiences of his father, who served in the Indian Air Force (IAF). Hearing enthusiastically the stories of thrills and frills of the skies, Nirmal Jit dreamt of enrolling himself into the IAF, one day. He was determined to become a fighter pilot, come what may!

He studied in Khalsa High School, Ajitsar Mohie, near Ludhiana, and secured a first division in matriculation. He joined the Dayalbagh Engineering College, Agra in 1962. While being a cadet in the National Cadet Corps (NCC), he was keenly interested in aero modelling. However, he left the engineering course midway to pursue his dream of joining the IAF especially after the 1965 war.

Despite many obstacles, Nirmal Jit Singh Sekhon soon achieved his lifelong ambition. He was commissioned in the IAF on 4 June 1967. As he was very tall, it was uncomfortable for him to fit into the diminutive Gnat fighter aircraft! However, he soon became adept at flying the Gnat. Known for his generosity and friendly nature, he was warmly addressed as 'Brother'. He joined the No. 18 Squadron, called 'Flying Bullets', as Flying Officer in October 1968.

Safeguarding the Skies

Pakistan began the 1971 war by launching air raids across Northwest India. Many airfields came under the attack of the Pakistan Air

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Force (PAF) aircrafts. Since 1948, India could not station air defence aircraft at Srinagar owing to an international agreement. But due to the war, a Gnat squadron detachment was based at Srinagar to defend the Kashmir valley. Nirmal Jit Singh Sekhon joined this detachment in challenging circumstances. He had to quickly acclimatise himself to the harsh winter. Undaunted, he gave the PAF a befitting reply.

On 14 December, the F-86 Sabre jet fighters of the PAF which took off from Peshawar airbase began to strafe the Srinagar airfield. Flying Officer Nirmal Jit Singh Sekhon was on readiness duty at that moment. The continuous surge of air attacks by the Pakistani pilots provided him the opportunity to display his mettle. Putting his life at grave risk, he took off in his Gnat aircraft. At the outset, it was evident that the odds were stacked against him. But he never failed to rise to the occasion. He began to engage the adversaries in fearsome battles in mid-air.

Manoeuvring his Gnat aircraft skilfully, Nirmal Jit Singh Sekhon intercepted as many as six Pakistani Sabre fighter aircrafts. He attacked Sabres and destroyed several of them. He communicated his steely resolve to the Combat Air Patrol (CAP) control room: '*I am behind two Sabres. I won't let the… get away*'. Even though he was fighting against overwhelming odds, he inflicted heavy damage on the PAF. Confident of his skills, he reigned supreme in the skies and put up a brave fight until the very end. He touched the sky with glory! His daring action in these dogfights dented the resolve of the enemy pilots and prevented them from achieving any significant breakthrough in Kashmir.

Flying Officer Sekhon was merely 26 years old when he laid down his life defending the motherland. He left behind his wife, Manjit Sekhon, to who he was married exactly 10 months back. (She remarried later). He is the one and only hero from the IAF to have been honoured with the Param Vir Chakra till date. His exceptional flying skills and awe-inspiring actions in the most adverse circumstances serve as a source of motivation for all those who seek to master air warfare.

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The Army Postal Service issued a Special Cover on 7 October 1982 to honour Flying Officer Nirmal Jit Singh Sekhon during the 50th Anniversary Year of the IAF. A commemorative postage stamp was issued in his honour by the Government of India on the occasion of the 50th Republic Day in 2000. His statues along with Gnat aircrafts were installed on the premises of the District Court, Ludhiana, Punjab and the Air Force Museum, Palam, New Delhi. The film, *Hindustan Ki Kasam* (1973), directed by Chetan Anand, portrayed the role of the IAF during the 1971 war.



Statue of Flying Officer Nirmal Jit Singh Sekhon with a Gnat aircraft at the Air Force Museum, Palam, New Delhi



Citation



Flying Officer Nirmal Jit Singh Sekhon (10877), Flying Branch (Pilot)

Flying Officer Nirmal Jit Singh Sekhon was a pilot of Gnat detachment based at Srinagar for the air defence of the valley against Pakistani air attacks. From the very outbreak of the hostilities he and his colleagues fought the successive waves of intruding Pakistani aircraft with valour and determination, maintaining the high reputation of the Gnat aircraft. On 14 December 1971, Srinagar airfield was attacked by a wave of six enemy Sabre aircrafts. Flying Officer Sekhon was on readiness duty at the time. Immediately, however, no fewer than six enemy aircrafts were overhead, and they began bombing and strafing the airfield. In spite of the mortal danger of attempting to take off during the attack, Flying Officer Sekhon took off and immediately engaged a pair of the attacking Sabres. In the fight that ensued, he secured hits on one aircraft and set another on fire. By this time, the other Sabre aircraft came to the aid of their hard-pressed companions and Flying Officer Sekhon's Gnat was again outnumbered, this time by four to one. Even though alone, Flying Officer Sekhon engaged the enemy in an unequal combat. In the fight that followed, at tree top height, he almost held his own, but was eventually overcome by sheer weight of numbers. His aircraft crashed and he was killed.

The sublime heroism, supreme gallantry, flying skill and determination above and beyond the call of duty displayed by Flying Officer Sekhon in the face of certain death, have set new heights to Air Force tradition.

Gazette of India Notification
No. 7– Pres./72

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14

Arun Khetarpal



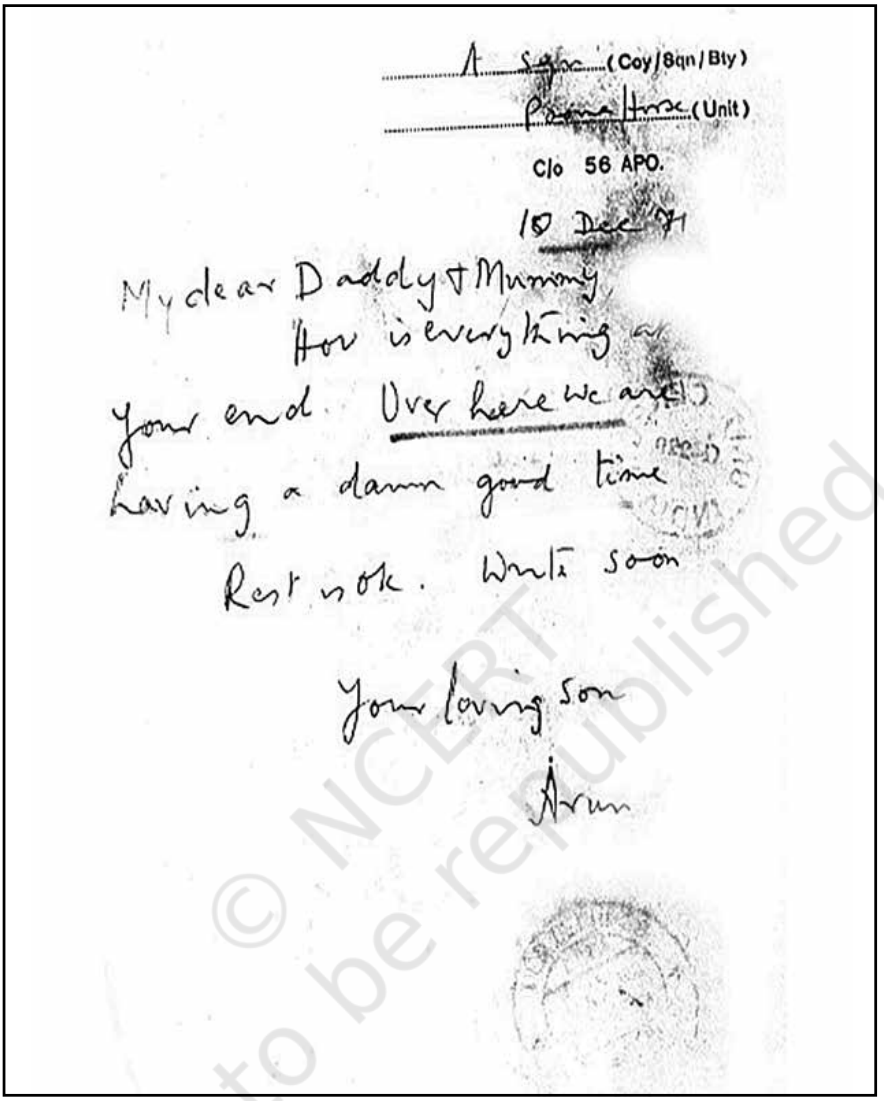
In 1950, the Year of the Republic, a boy named Arun was born on 14 October in Pune, Maharashtra. He was the elder son of Brig M.L. Khetarpal and Maheshwari Khetarpal. Several generations of his distinguished family had served in the armed forces. Among the institutions, he attended was the Lawrence School, Sanawar, Himachal Pradesh. Possessing a cheerful personality, he performed brilliantly both in academics and sports. Given his all-round performance, he became the school prefect. He always lived up to the school's motto: 'Never Give In'.

In 1967, he joined the National Defence Academy (NDA), Khadakwasla, Pune, and subsequently the Indian Military Academy (IMA), Dehradun. He was commissioned in the 17 Poona Horse on 13 June 1971.

Just six months later, the war began on 3 December 1971. During this war, like the 1965 war, tank battles were fierce and crucial. They were fought mostly in Punjab on the western front. Among them was the famous Battle of Basantar in the Shakargarh sector. Both sides wanted total control of this sector, owing to its strategic location. The border at this position is about ten kilometres from the Pathankot-Jammu Highway. The Indian troops reached ten miles inside the Pakistani territory. 2/Lt Arun Khetarpal was amidst the action in this battle commanding a Centurion tank named Famagusta.

As part of the operations, the 17 Poona Horse had to establish a bridgehead across the Basantar River, a tributary of the Ravi river.

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A Sqn (Coy/Sqn/Bty)
Poona Horse (Unit)
C/o 56 APO.
10 Dec 71
My dear Daddy & Mummy,
How is everything at your end. Over here we are (illegible) having a damn good time. Rest ok. Write soon.
Your loving son
Arun

2/Lt Arun Khetarpal's letter to his parents from the battlefield on 10 December 1971

This was accomplished by the night of 15 December. The area was full of enemy minefields. Noticing the action of enemy armour at the bridgehead, the Indian troops called for tank support urgently.

The 17 Poona Horse decided to embark on a dangerous mission to push through the deadly minefield. By midnight, this regiment had established a link-up between the armour and the infantry at the bridgehead. On the morning of 16 December, the enemy

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counterattacked with an armour regiment. Sadly, the Indian troops were heavily outnumbered and therefore sought reinforcements. 2/Lt Arun Khetarpal, deployed at a nearby location with his troops, decided to take on the enemy head-on. His troops came under incessant firing from the enemy forces. Still he retaliated by attacking the enemy positions and totally destroying them. Invigorated with this success, he began to pursue the enemy tanks. But, the enemy soon deployed a complete armoured squadron to achieve a breakthrough.

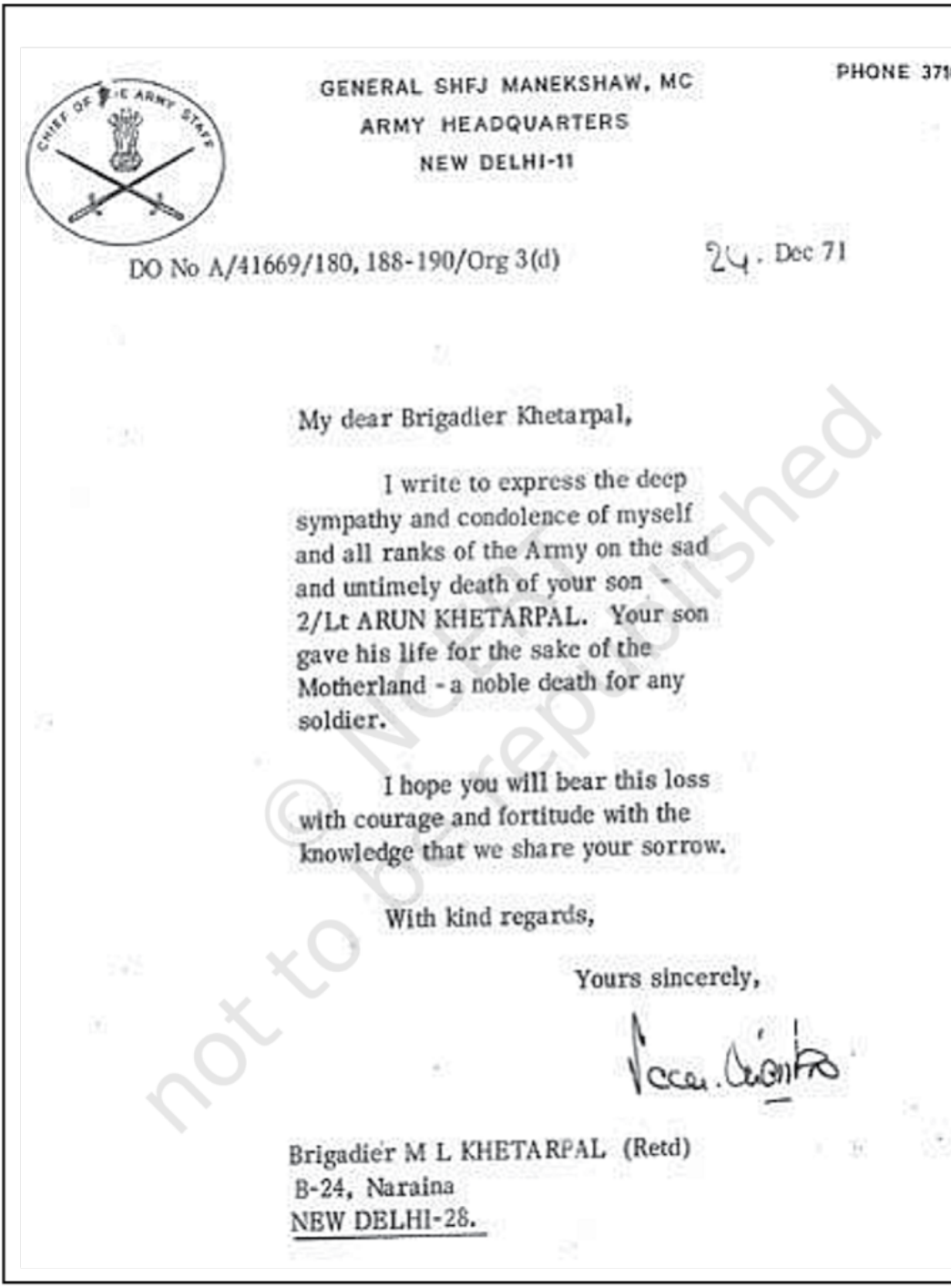
A Fight to the Death

In the fierce tank battles that followed, 2/Lt Khetarpal single-handedly destroyed many enemy tanks. Just then, his tank received a hit from the enemy and was partially destroyed. Sensing an immediate threat to his life, his superior sent him urgent orders to abandon the burning tank. But he politely refused to comply and responded with the following message: "*No Sir, I will not abandon my tank. My gun is still working and I will get these....*"

Displaying grim determination, he began the final assault on the remaining enemy tanks from a close range. He shot the last enemy tank, barely 100 metres away. At this stage, his tank received one more hit. But then, a will of iron was his best weapon! He offered solid resistance to the enemy tanks and prevented a breakthrough until he breathed his last. The day of martyrdom of Arun Khetarpal, 16 December, coincided with the surrender of the Pakistani forces on the eastern front. This day is commemorated as the *Vijay Diwas* (Victory Day).

For his conspicuous courage in the face of the enemy, 2/Lt Arun Khetarpal was honoured with the Param Vir Chakra, posthumously. The Khetarpal Parade Ground at NDA and the Khetarpal Auditorium at IMA are everlasting tributes to his valour. His heroic deeds in the battlefield serve as an abiding source of inspiration for generations to come.

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GENERAL SHFJ MANEKSHAW, MC
ARMY HEADQUARTERS
NEW DELHI-11

PHONE 371632

DO No A/41669/180, 188-190/Org 3(d)

24 Dec 71

My dear Brigadier Khetarpal,

I write to express the deep sympathy and condolence of myself and all ranks of the Army on the sad and untimely death of your son - 2/Lt ARUN KHETARPAL. Your son gave his life for the sake of the Motherland - a noble death for any soldier.

I hope you will bear this loss with courage and fortitude with the knowledge that we share your sorrow.

With kind regards,

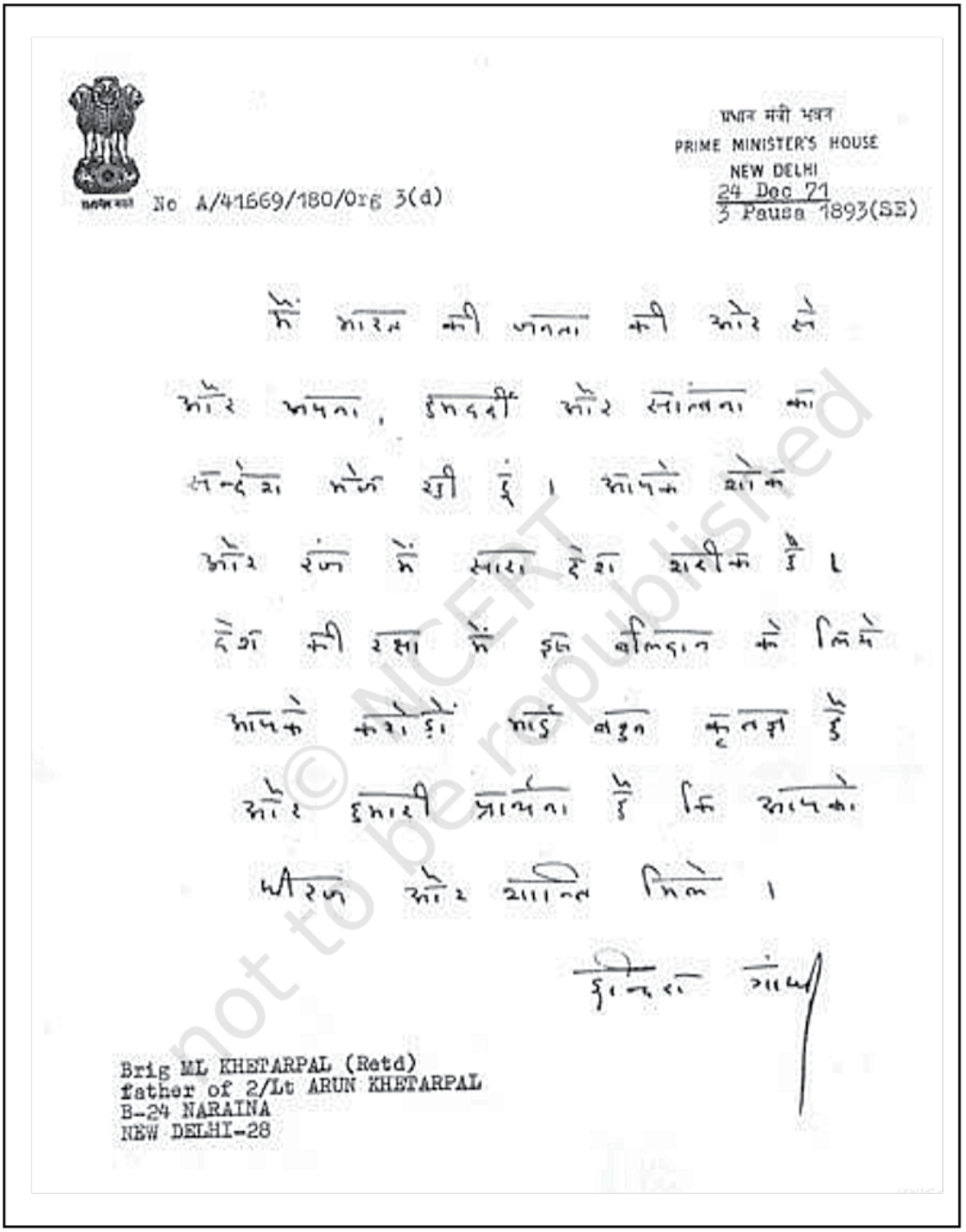
Yours sincerely,

Sam Manekshaw

Brigadier M L KHETARPAL (Retd)
B-24, Naraina
NEW DELHI-28.

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Chief of the Army Staff, Gen Manekshaw's condolence letter commending the valour of 2/Lt Arun Khetarpal (24 December 1971)



प्रधान मंत्री भवन
PRIME MINISTER'S HOUSE
NEW DELHI
24 Dec 71
3 Pausa 1893(SE)

No A/41669/180/Org 3(d)

Brig ML KHETARPAL (Retd)
father of 2/Lt ARUN KHETARPAL
B-24 NARAINA
NEW DELHI-28

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Prime Minister Indira Gandhi's letter of condolence and appreciation of the sacrifice by 2/Lt Arun Khetarpal (24 December 1971)



Unveiling of the statue of 2/Lt Arun Khetarpal at his alma mater, the Lawrence School, Sanawar on 3 December 2011



Tank of 2/Lt Arun Khetarpal at the Armoured Corps Centre and School, Ahmednagar, Maharashtra

Citation



Second Lieutenant Arun Khetarpal (IC-25067), Poona Horse

On 16 December 1971, when our position at Jarpal in the Shakargarh sector was subjected to an attack by a Pakistani armoured regiment and our troops were heavily outnumbered by enemy forces, the squadron commander asked for reinforcements. 2/Lt Khetarpal on hearing this transmission over the radio answered the call and moved with his troops to meet the enemy attack. On the way, his troops came under fire from enemy strong points and Recoilless Gun nests that were still holding out in the bridgehead established across the Basantar river by our troops. Realising that a critical situation was developing and prompt action was to be taken, 2/Lt Khetarpal assaulted the enemy strong points, physically overrunning them and capturing the enemy's infantry and weapon crews at pistol point. In the course of this action, the commander of one of the tanks in his troop was killed, but 2/Lt Khetarpal continued to attack relentlessly till all opposition was overcome and he broke through towards the location of our squadron. When the enemy tanks started pulling back after their initial probing attacks, he chased them and destroyed one of them.

When the enemy launched another attack, with an armoured squadron, against the sector held by three of our tanks, one of which was manned by 2/Lt Khetarpal, a fierce battle ensued and 10 enemy tanks were hit and destroyed of which 2/Lt Khetarpal personally destroyed four. In the fight, 2/Lt Khetarpal's tank was hit and it burst into flames and he was severely wounded. 2/Lt Khetarpal was ordered to abandon his tank but realising that the enemy was still pressing their attack in this sector and that if he abandoned his tank, there was nothing to stop the enemy from breaking through. In spite of grievous wounds and his own tank burning, he continued engaging the enemy tanks and destroyed one more. At this stage, his tank was hit a second time as a

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result of which he died but the enemy was denied the breakthrough, he was seeking so desperately.

In this action, 2/Lt Arun Khetarpal displayed most conspicuous gallantry in the face of the enemy, indomitable fighting spirit and tenacity of purpose.

Gazette of India Notification
No. 7 – Pres./72

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Khetarpal Parade Ground, National Defence Academy

15

Hoshiar Singh



There was a bright boy named Hoshiar in village Sisana of district Sonipat, Haryana. He was born on 5 May 1936 and his parents were Chowdhury Hira Singh and Mathuri Devi. Hailing from a farming family, he used to assist his parents in their fields.

Hoshiar Singh initially studied at a local school and then moved to the Jat Higher Secondary School and the Jat College, Rohtak. He performed well in studies and was awarded a first division in matriculation examination. He was a top-class volleyball player and soon became the captain of the Punjab team, which landed him a place in the national team.

Belonging to a village that has contributed more than 250 soldiers to the Indian Army, he was keen to join the army. He joined 2 Jat Regiment in 1957 as a soldier. Six years later, he became an officer by clearing the examination for promotion in his first attempt. He was commissioned in the Grenadiers Regiment on 30 June 1963. While serving in the North East Frontier Agency (NEFA), his bravery along with remarkable skills in leadership came to be noticed. He also played a crucial role in the Bikaner sector during the 1965 Indo-Pak war. Taking the initiative, he displayed his courage and dogged determination during the operations. For his brave acts, he received a Mention-in-Despatches. A greater role was in store for him six years later!

Indomitable Spirit Comes to the Fore

Soon after the 1971 war began on the western front, the 3rd Battalion of the Grenadiers Regiment spearheaded the campaign in the

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Shakargarh sector. Maj Hoshiar Singh was a proud member of this unit. This battalion rapidly advanced during the first ten days. On 15 December, it was assigned the task of establishing a bridgehead across the Basantar River. However, the enemy troops had laid deep minefields on both sides of the river and were in a strong position. The advancing Indian troops came under intense shelling and suffered heavily. But under the courageous leadership of Maj Hoshiar Singh, they continued the assault doggedly and captured village Jarpal in the Punjab province of Pakistan. The enemy troops launched massive counter-attacks with the help of tanks.

Maj Hoshiar Singh was a true leader. Leading from the front, he provided inspiring leadership. He continuously motivated his men in the face of grave threats to perform at the highest level. His courage encouraged them to give their best. Under his dynamic leadership, his company repulsed all attacks, inflicting heavy casualties on the enemy.

Although hostilities ended on the eastern front by the evening of 16 December, the battles continued on the western front. On 17 December, the enemy troops launched yet another major attack with the support of heavy artillery. Maj Hoshiar Singh was seriously wounded by the enemy shelling. Despite this, he openly moved from trench to trench raising the morale of his soldiers. Nothing could hold him back! He continued to inflict heavy casualties on the enemy troops, forcing them to retreat. They left behind many dead, including their Commanding Officer, Lt Col Mohammed Akram Raja.

Maj Hoshiar Singh, thus, engaged the enemy forces in a steadfast manner. His dogged resistance, complete disregard for his personal safety and exemplary courage propelled his men to perform outstanding acts of gallantry. They foiled repeated attempts by the enemy to recapture the area. They lived up to his example. Although he was seriously wounded, he refused to be evacuated till the end of operations. He did not leave the battlefield until India was victorious! This was certainly an act beyond the call of duty. He was honoured with the highest wartime gallantry

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medal, the Param Vir Chakra. Maj Hoshiar Singh was the sole PVC Awardee of the 1971 war to receive it in person.

Maj Hoshiar Singh was a taskmaster as well as a caring person. He possessed thorough knowledge of the men he was commanding during times of peace as well as war. He used to stress upon rigorous training and practice on a regular basis. He contributed immensely to develop spirit of camaraderie, be it at the workplace or on the battlefield. When he served as a Company Commander at the IMA, his company became the overall champion company for six consecutive terms! This is a record that continues to remain unbroken. He rose to the rank of colonel prior to his retirement. Unfortunately, he suffered a heart attack and passed away on 6 December 1998 at the age of 62 leaving behind his wife, Dhanno Devi and three sons.



Maj Hoshiar Singh with the Chief of the Army Staff, Gen Manekshaw (1972)





Col Hoshiar Singh Memorial Primary School, Sisana, Haryana, with his bust

Citation



Major Hoshiar Singh (IC-14608), 3 Grenadiers

On 15 December 1971, a battalion of the Grenadiers was given the task of establishing a bridgehead across the Basantar river in the Shakargarh sector. Major Hoshiar Singh was commanding the left forward company and he was ordered to capture the enemy locality at Jarpal. This was a well fortified position and was held in strength by the enemy. During the assault, his company came under intense shelling and effective crossfire from enemy Medium Machine Guns. Undeterred, he led the charge, and captured the objective after a fierce hand-to-hand fight. The enemy reacted and put in three counter-attacks on 16 December 1971, two of them supported by armour. Major Hoshiar Singh, unmindful of the heavy shelling and tank fire, went from trench to trench, motivating his command and encouraging his men to stand fast and fight. Inspired by his courage and dauntless leadership, his company repulsed all the attacks inflicting heavy casualties on the enemy. Again, on 17 December 1971, the enemy made another attack with a battalion supported by heavy artillery fire. Though seriously wounded by enemy shelling, Major Hoshiar Singh again went from trench to trench moving about in the open with utter disregard to his personal safety when an enemy shell landed near the Medium Machine Gun post injuring the crew and rendering it inoperative. Major Hoshiar Singh, realising the importance of the Machine Gun fire, immediately rushed to the Machine Gun pit and, though seriously wounded himself, manned the gun inflicting heavy casualties on the enemy. The attack was successfully repulsed and the enemy retreated leaving behind 85 dead including their Commanding Officer and three other officers. Though seriously wounded, Major Hoshiar Singh refused to be evacuated till the ceasefire.

Throughout this operation, Major Hoshiar Singh displayed most conspicuous gallantry, indomitable fighting spirit and leadership in the highest traditions of the Army.

Gazette of India Notification
No. 7 – Pres./72